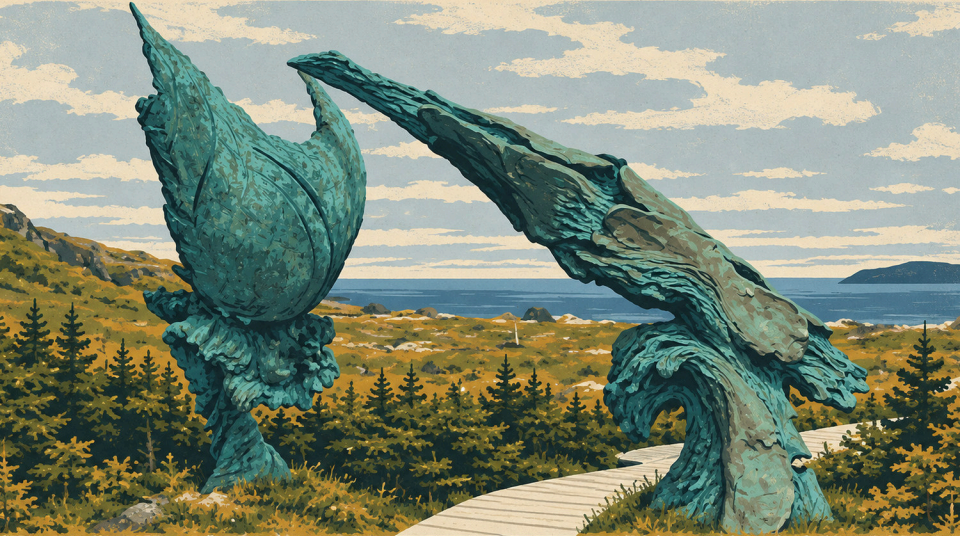




L'ANSE AUX MEADOWS

NEWFOUNDLAND AND LABRADOR

POST CARD

Hello nephew!

As you know, I spent a lot of time travelling to explore our Norse heritage. As I travelled, I collected fun stuff for you.

I know you love puzzles, so I created an adventure for you! With a surprise at the end!

You will explore the history of Leif Erikson, Rollo the Walker, And the Deep-Minded and Harald Hardrada.

This postcard comes from the first stop of my journey and should help you get started!

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

L'Anse aux Meadows was found after a local man pointed out odd bumps in a meadow. It is still the only confirmed Norse site in North America.



BATTLE HARBOUR

NEWFOUNDLAND AND LABRADOR

POST CARD

Markland today – 'Forest Land' in the old sagas, and they weren't exaggerating, it is gorgeous! Trees for miles, beautiful light and no one around!

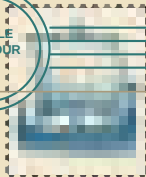
The sky here is enormous, though somehow it always looks half finished.

Still, you'd love it here.

Love,
Aunt Liv



BATTLE
HARBOUR



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

While the Vikings never permanently settled there, they used the Labrador coast as a medieval logging camp and named it Markland — “Forest Land” in Old Norse.



BAFFIN ISLAND

NUNAVUT

POST CARD

New stop: Helluland, "Flat Stone Land" to the sagas – and they weren't Kidding about the stone either, not a tree in sight!

But last night the sky put on a show I'll never forget: green and purple curtains rippling right overhead. I stood out in the cold far too long just watching. Almost missed my supper!

Between this sky and Markland's, I think I've finally seen the whole thing.

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

The saga says the stones here were so big that two men could lie on them heel-to-heel.



BRATTAHLÍÐ

GREENLAND

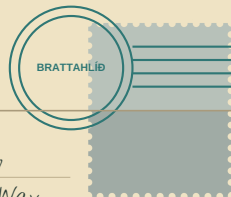
POST CARD

Amazing place today! Brattahlíð, Greenland where Leif actually grew up.

It's stunning here! Erik apparently picked the name "Greenland" on purpose, to lure settlers! Funny how a name can cast a spell like that. I really enjoy those small details!

I hope you enjoy this puzzle, there might be a few steps to get the final code.

With Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Leif's mother built Greenland's first church here. It was tiny and turf-walled, and the saga says she put it well away from pagan Erik's farmhouse.



CHÂLUS

HAUTE-VIENNE

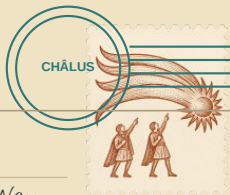
POST CARD

Châlus, where Richard the Lionheart's whole story ends.

He was besieging a tiny castle here over a supposed treasure hoard, of all things, when a crossbow bolt caught him in the shoulder.

Found an old carving near the gate of a bolt just like the one that got him.

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Richard the Lionheart (a direct descendant of Rollo) was shot here in April 1199. Legend says he pardoned the archer before he died.



ROUEN

NORMANDY

POST CARD

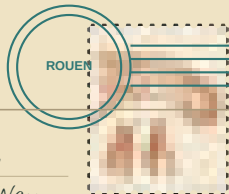
Today I got to visit Rouen, this was Rollo's own city! The King gave Rollo all of Normandy so the fighting would stop.

The city was vibrant today with lots of people milling about.

All that walking around made me crave fast-food: the battered poultry from Kentucky. Tonight's dinner was a bit fancier, the Inn I'm staying at is famous for their snails!

Maybe I should count the distances between my stops to show how many steps I took.

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Rouen Cathedral holds the actual heart of Richard the Lionheart, King of England and Duke of Normandy.



BAYEUX

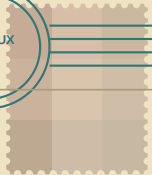
NORMANDY

POST CARD

Today was Bayeux and its famous Norman tapestry. The tapestry was awesome! It tells the story of William the Conqueror (a direct descendant of Rollo!) taking England.

I'm obsessed with the style and you know how much I like to draw, can you find what it means?

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

The Bayeux Tapestry shows Halley's Comet blazing over King Harold's court just before Hastings — the earliest known depiction of the comet, centuries before it got its name.



WINCHESTER

ENGLAND

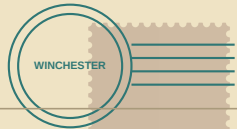
POST CARD

Winchester today – freezing here,
but worth every minute. This
cathedral is where Richard the
Lionheart was crowned a second
time.

Another one of Rollo's own line!
Funny to think it's all because of
one deal, centuries earlier.

I got to enjoy the local custom of a
scone and hot beverage.

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

The Round Table hanging in
Winchester's Great Hall is a
genuine medieval artifact — just
not King Arthur's.



BATTLE

EAST SUSSEX

POST CARD

Today I visited Battle, the village where the Battle of Hastings happened. It's so cool to be able to see it in person, especially after seeing it on the tapestry! But it doesn't really measure up to what the tapestry depicts.

I hope you're enjoying my drawings! Good thing I packed my old ruler: they only make sense at the right scale.

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

The Bayeux Tapestry's famous scene of Harold clutching an arrow in his eye may not be original — Victorian restorers reworked stitching in that exact spot.



ROUMARE FOREST

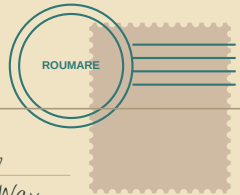
NORMANDY

POST CARD

Rollo's own Normandy, and this little forest just outside Rouen has a local legend all its own, though nobody can really pin the story down.

What I can tell you is the wild boars are real: I counted a few slipping through the beech and oak, and for every one I actually saw, I'd bet good money there was a second one just out of sight.

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

In 911 the Treaty of Saint-Clair-sur-Epte handed Rollo all of Normandy, with Rouen as his new capital: the deal that turned a Viking raider into a duke.



WALCHEREN

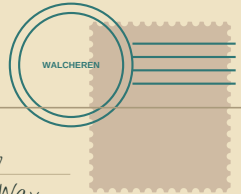
NETHERLANDS

POST CARD

Walcheren, in the Netherlands,
where Vikings had already carved
out their own toeholds on this coast
– maybe even Rollo himself, if the
old chronicles are to be believed.

Spent the evening watching the
fishing boats come in with the tide
and thought about him doing the
exact same, centuries back.

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

This stretch of coast saw Viking
fleets wintering here for years
before 911, when Rollo swapped
raiding for a dukedom just south
of here.



DÖGURÐARNES

ICELAND

POST CARD

Dögurðarnes today.

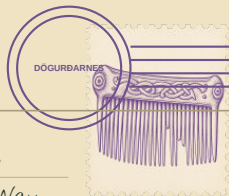
What a beautiful place, I understand why Aud stopped here during her journey.

I heard you can find some treasure around here, especially historical coins that fetch a pretty penny!

I was mostly interested in the coins from the treasure hunt though.

With love,

Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Dögurðarnes takes its name from dögurður, an Old Norse word for the day's main meal — a rest stop preserved in the map itself, long before it was a place anyone lived.



HVAMMUR

ICELAND

POST CARD

Hvammur today.

Such a lovely place and a great museum dedicated to Aud.

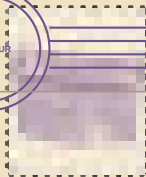
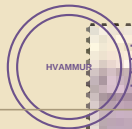
They even had a treasure hunt to find artifacts from Aud's time.

I was able to solve it and had a lovely time discovering the countryside. I particularly enjoyed the road that followed the forest.

It was fun to count how many bridges, fords and gates I crossed.

With love,

Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Aud claimed the entire valley between two rivers here in Dalasysla, then freed every thrall aboard her ships and granted each one land of their own.

ESJUBERG

ICELAND



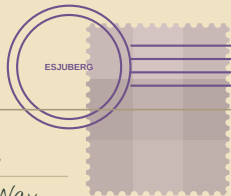
POST CARD

Esjuberg today.

Another beautiful place that Aud the Deep-Minded visited, my head is spinning with all the amazing landscapes!

Still amazed by the treasures I found!

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Esjuberg, on Kjalarnes, is where Laxdæla saga places Aud's meeting with her brother Helgi — and her refusal of his offer to settle down.



BJARNARHÖFN

ICELAND



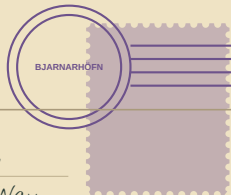
POST CARD

At her brother's harbor – the one
Aunt wintered in.

I've read everything I could find
about her this trip, to the point
that she feels like family (and she
actually maybe was).

It was so awesome to find that
comb alongside the coins, and the
museum let me keep it!

This is actually the real treasure,
a piece of history that we can use!
With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Bjarnarhöfn is famous for hákarl:
Greenland shark fermented, then
hung to dry for months. It smells
exactly as bad as it sounds.



OSLO

NORWAY

POST CARD

I'm spending a whole week in Oslo,
so much to do!

It's Harald's city – so much Viking
history.

Found the quirkiest little museum
near the harbour, all about
hnefatafl, the chess-like old board
game the Vikings loved and that we
used to play with our own rules
when you were younger. Grabbed you
a little souvenir from the gift shop
so you can try – can you get the
King to escape in exactly 3 moves?
Count how far he travels each
time.

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

King Harald Hardrada established
Oslo as a designated trading
place. It was renamed Christiania
for centuries before finally
returning to the name Oslo.



STARAYA LADOGA

RUSSIA

POST CARD

Dinners take hours here and
nobody rushes, which suits me
fine.

Rurik supposedly ruled from right
here, if the old chronicles are
true.

I climbed up on the fortress wall
for a look at the whole river
bend.

Nobody warned me how far this
feels from anywhere else.

Keeping up with new puzzles for
you is starting to be a challenge!

Love,
Aunt Liv



STARAYA
LADOGA



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

A wooden stick carved with Viking
runes was found here — probably
a scrap of poetry, and one of the
oldest runic finds in Russia.



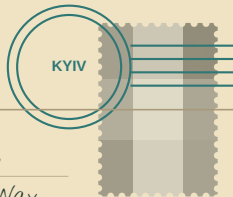
KYIV
UKRAINE

POST CARD

Kyiv, and it might be the most beautiful city on this whole trip – golden domes catching the light on every hill.

Here's a little riddle for you, the Kind we used to trade back and forth: I'm sweet, but no fruit tree grew me. I'm gold, but no smith ever cast me. Thousands of tiny workers made me and set six-sided walls to guard me.

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Harald married Elisiv, daughter of Kyiv's Grand Prince Yaroslav, after years abroad earning a fortune to win her.



HEDEBY

GERMANY

POST CARD

Today: Hedeby – barely a Hedeby left. From here I'm turning south: nothing but Mediterranean weather for the rest of this trip.

A woodcarver showed me how the old branch-runes worked – count the branches one way for the family, the other way for the letter.

Love,
Aunt Liv

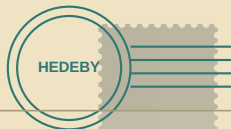
his Key, copied out:

1 – f a þ ö r k

2 – h n i a s

3 – t b m l r

(left branches = which row. right = where in it.)



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

During his war with Denmark, Harald burned Hedeby to the ground — sailing burning ships straight into the harbour.



SICILY

ITALY

POST CARD

Aci Castello today.

A Norman Castle in Sicily! It's crazy to think how far they travelled!

Being a good tourist, I enjoyed a gelato while walking around the ruins. Little did I know, that is a great way to attract wildlife. A RAVEN followed me the whole time! Half convinced it was you, checking up on me.

Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Aci Castello's rock is lava that cooled underwater into glassy basalt pillars. The castle sits on top of an old eruption.



PATARA

TURKEY

POST CARD

Patara is the last stop of my travels for now.

I had so much fun exploring the Vikings and Norse travels!

For your university summer break, I would love for you to join me on my next adventure. You have one more puzzle to solve and you will get your rewards!

Now you should have all you need to retrace my steps!

With love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

Archaeologists discovered a Viking sword at the Patara excavation site. It almost certainly belonged to a soldier of the Varangian Guard, of which Harald was a prominent member.



CONSTANTINOPLE

TURKEY

POST CARD

Constantinople – well, Istanbul now,
but I like the old name for this
trip.

Impossible not to think about
Harald everywhere here, this is
where he made his fortune, long
before Norway ever heard of him.
Found this in a little shop near the
Hippodrome, couldn't resist.



Love,
Aunt Liv



TO

John Ericson

24 Longship Way

Ottawa ON K1L 1S1

Canada

FUN FACT

A Viking carved "Halfdan was here" in runes on a marble balustrade in Hagia Sophia. It's still there.